For many Russian observers, however, the mysterious death coupled with the suspicious disappearance of Vitkevitch's Afghan papers bore all the hallmarks of British foul play. After all, Vitkevitch's papers contained details of the British intelligence and news-writing networks in Central Asia that he had successfully penetrated. As L. G. Sinyavin, the new director of the Asiatic Department, noted in a letter shortly afterwards:

> He burned our papers without handing them over. Those papers constituted various observations to assist him in drawing up a report on the affairs of Afghanistan and copies of the despatches of British agents to various individuals in Afghanistan. In a word, with him perished all the valuable information about Afghanistan which would now be particularly precious and useful to us and which, from his remarkable talents and gifts of observation, we have every reason to suppose his papers contained. Only what he personally managed to relate to me is known.[5]

All this led to speculation that Vitkevitch's shooting was in fact a covert assassination by British intelligence agents. There was, after all, no reason why Vitkevitch should commit suicide, given that – according to the official Russian version of events – he had been received with honour, promoted, told he was in line for a medal, and was about to be received by Tsar Nicholas I for a personal interview on the very morning of his death. Why would such a man kill himself on the eve of his great moment of glory? Sinyavin for one was baffled. 'Vitkevitch had only arrived in St Petersburg eight days previously,' he wrote to Perovsky, Vitkevitch's patron in Orenburg. 'He was extremely well received by the Ministry and on the very day of his death the report came through authorising his transfer to the guards, and on top of that, rewards of promotion, honours and money.' Sinyavin continued:

> During my meeting with him, I recounted what a favourable interest you took in him, of your anxiety on hearing [falsely that] he had gone to Khiva and been killed, and how before his departure you had especially recommended that I organise a decent reward for him for such a difficult expedition. He seemed very satisfied and merry, and a day before his death I saw him at the theatre, where he sat the whole evening and chatted with Prince Saltykov. On the eve of his suicide they saw him again in the middle of the day, and again he was merry; in the evening he visited Count Simonitch . . . It is all very strange . . .[6]

According to this Russian version, Vitkevitch was in the highest spirits throughout his trip to St Petersburg. Vitkevitch's Orenburg friend K. Bukh described how they got together that morning and 'went for a ride in the islands', then saw a play in the Kamennoostrovsky Theatre. 'He did not